FOX AUTOMOTIVE SALES ACADEMY

Module 2: Types of Guests

Understanding customer behavior, adapting communication, and maintaining control of the sales process.

Learning Objectives

- Understand why customer behavior should change communication, not the sales process.
- Identify common guest types within the first 60-90 seconds of the interaction.
- Adjust tone, pace, question style, and amount of explanation based on customer behavior.
- Maintain control of the process without sounding aggressive, scripted, or pushy.
- Recognize where deals are lost because the salesperson misread the customer.

1. Where Deals Are Actually Lost

Most salespeople believe deals are won or lost at the desk. They think the payment was too high, the price was too high, the customer needed to think about it, or the manager could not make the numbers work. Sometimes those things matter, but they are rarely where the breakdown truly began.

Many deals are lost in the first few minutes. They are lost when the salesperson talks too much to a customer who wants speed, rushes a customer who needs time, pushes a customer who does not trust them yet, or gives price to a customer who has not been sold on the vehicle.

When a salesperson misreads the customer, the rest of the process becomes harder. The customer may still be polite. They may still test drive. They may even sit down at the desk. But mentally, resistance has already started.

Core Principle

You do not lose most deals at the end. You lose them early when the customer feels misunderstood, rushed, ignored, pressured, or handled the wrong way.

2. Every Customer Is Different, The Process Is Not

Every customer brings a different personality, different expectations, and a different level of preparation. Some customers have researched online for weeks. Some arrive unsure and need guidance. Some are cautious because they have had a bad experience before. Some are focused heavily on price because they believe that is the only way to protect themselves.

Because of this, many salespeople make a critical mistake. They think they need to change the sales process to match the customer. They skip qualification, rush the walkaround, avoid the test drive, or jump directly into numbers because the customer pushed them there.

That is not adapting. That is reacting.

A professional salesperson runs the same process with every customer while making the communication feel personal. The steps stay consistent. The tone, pace, and questions change.

Core Principle

You do not adjust the process to the customer. You adjust your communication to the customer.

- The researcher needs tighter communication.
- The emotional buyer needs connection and experience.
- The price-focused buyer needs value built before negotiation.
- The skeptic needs calm consistency before pressure.

Performance Standard

If a step is skipped, it must be a controlled decision, not a reaction to customer pressure.

3. The Three Questions Every Customer Is Asking

Every customer, regardless of personality type, is trying to answer three questions during the buying process. They may not say them out loud, but these questions determine whether they move forward or create resistance.

Customer Question	What It Means	Salesperson Responsibility
Can I trust you?	The customer is deciding if you are honest, prepared, and working in their best interest.	Create confidence through tone, clarity, listening, and follow-through.
Is this the right vehicle?	The customer is deciding if the vehicle fits their needs, wants, life, family, and budget.	Qualify properly and connect features to what matters to them.
Am I getting a fair deal?	The customer is deciding if the numbers make sense and if they are being treated fairly.	Build value before negotiating and explain next steps clearly.

Different customers simply prioritize these questions differently. A skeptical customer needs trust first. An emotional buyer needs vehicle connection first. A price-focused buyer often tries to force fairness first. A researcher usually wants efficiency and confirmation first.

Reality Check

If you answer the wrong question first, even with the right words, the customer may still pull away.

4. The Fox Guest Control System

The Fox Guest Control System is simple, but it requires discipline. The salesperson must identify the customer type, match their communication style, and lead the interaction to the next step. This must happen early. If the customer takes control before the salesperson establishes direction, the rest of the deal becomes reactive.

Step	What It Means	What It Looks Like
Identify	Recognize the customer's communication style and buying concern.	Listen to words, pace, tone, body language, and first questions.
Match	Adjust how you communicate without abandoning the process.	Change pace, depth, tone, and question style.
Lead	Guide the customer to the next step with confidence and clarity.	Move to qualification, vehicle selection, demo, test drive, or write-up.

Performance Standard

Within 60-90 seconds, the salesperson should be forming a read on the customer and adjusting communication accordingly.

5. Guest Type: The Researcher

The researcher has already invested time before engaging the dealership. They may have compared vehicles, watched videos, reviewed inventory, checked incentives, or looked at third-party pricing. This customer often arrives with specific information and expects the dealership experience to be efficient.

Behavior Profile

- Prepared before arrival
- Direct in communication
- Low tolerance for wasted time
- Often knows vehicle, trim, color, payment range, or advertised offer

What They Are Really Thinking

I already did the work. Do not slow me down or make this harder than it needs to be.

Where Salespeople Fail

Salespeople fail with this customer by over-explaining, repeating information the customer already knows, or trying to "sell" before confirming what the customer came in to accomplish. The researcher does not want a lecture. They want accuracy, speed, and a professional guide who can refine the decision.

Correct Approach

Acknowledge the customer's preparation. Respect their time. Ask direct questions that confirm details and move quickly to the next logical step. This customer still needs a process, but the communication must be tighter.

Acceptable Language

- “Sounds like you’ve already done your homework. Let me make sure we have the exact vehicle you’re looking for so we can save you time.”
- “What specifically caught your attention on that one?”
- “Let me verify availability and then we’ll make sure it fits what you’re trying to accomplish.”

Performance Standard

Fast customer equals tight communication. Reduce friction. Do not add noise.

6. Guest Type: The Emotional Buyer

The emotional buyer is influenced by how the vehicle feels, how the experience feels, and whether they can picture themselves owning it. This customer may not always communicate in exact specifications. They often respond to comfort, color, design, technology, safety, lifestyle, and how the vehicle fits their identity or family.

Behavior Profile

- Feeling-driven and experience-driven
- Responsive to connection and energy
- Often unsure early in the process
- Needs help turning interest into ownership

What They Are Really Thinking

I want to feel good about this decision.

Where Salespeople Fail

Salespeople fail with this customer by rushing to numbers, skipping rapport, or treating the interaction like a transaction. When the salesperson moves too fast, the customer loses the emotional connection that often creates the buying decision.

Correct Approach

Slow the process down without losing direction. Ask lifestyle questions, build connection, demonstrate the vehicle, and help the customer imagine ownership before moving into negotiation.

Acceptable Language

- “Let’s take a look at a couple options and see what feels right for you.”
- “When you picture yourself driving this every day, what matters most?”
- “Based on what you told me, this is the part I think you’ll appreciate most.”

Performance Standard

If you rush emotion, you kill the deal. Let the customer experience the vehicle before forcing the decision.

7. Guest Type: The Price-Focused Buyer

The price-focused buyer is concerned with getting a fair deal and often attempts to move the conversation directly into numbers. This customer may be comparing multiple stores, may have had a prior poor experience, or may believe that negotiating early is the only way to avoid being taken advantage of.

Behavior Profile

- Direct about price or payment
- Often compares stores or online offers
- Tests confidence and control
- May attempt to skip qualification and demonstration

What They Are Really Thinking

If I push, will you break?

Where Salespeople Fail

Salespeople fail with this customer by giving price too early, becoming defensive, apologizing for the number, or going to the manager before value has been built. Once negotiation starts before the vehicle is confirmed, the salesperson is playing from behind.

Correct Approach

Acknowledge the price concern without surrendering control. Re-anchor the conversation to vehicle fit, value, trade, incentives, and total ownership before negotiation begins.

Acceptable Language

- “I’ll make sure you get a great deal. First, let’s make sure this is the right vehicle so we’re not negotiating the wrong one.”
- “Price matters. I agree. The fastest way to get you a real answer is to make sure we are on the right vehicle and the right structure.”
- “Let’s make sure we have the vehicle, equipment, and terms right, then we can put the numbers together properly.”

Performance Standard

If you answer price before value and fit are established, you give up leverage and start working for the customer instead of guiding the customer.

8. Guest Type: The Skeptical Buyer

The skeptical buyer enters the dealership guarded. They may distrust dealerships in general, may have had a bad experience before, or may believe that every salesperson is trying to manipulate them. This customer is watching for inconsistency, pressure, exaggeration, or anything that confirms their fear.

Behavior Profile

- Guarded and cautious
- Low initial trust
- May challenge statements or ask for proof

- Often sensitive to tone and pressure

What They Are Really Thinking

Do not screw me.

Where Salespeople Fail

Salespeople fail with this customer by arguing, defending the dealership too hard, over-explaining, or trying to win the trust battle immediately. When the salesperson sounds defensive, the customer feels justified in staying guarded.

Correct Approach

Acknowledge the concern calmly. Do not argue with their past experience. Create trust through consistency, transparency, and controlled next steps. This customer must be won steadily, not forced quickly.

Acceptable Language

- “I understand. A lot of people feel that way at first. Let’s take this one step at a time and make sure everything makes sense.”
- “That is fair. I’ll keep everything clear and if something does not make sense, stop me and we’ll go through it.”
- “My job is to give you the information clearly so you can make the right decision.”

Performance Standard

You do not win skeptics fast. You win them steadily through tone, clarity, and follow-through.

Final Message to the Sales Professional

You will not lose most deals because of price. You will lose them because you failed to understand the person in front of you. The process gives you structure. Your ability to read, adjust, and lead gives you control. When you combine both, you stop guessing and start selling professionally.

Closing Line

At Fox Automotive, we do not treat every customer the same. We observe, adjust, and lead.